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The Role of the Possessor/HAVE-Relation in Semantics

Friederike Moltmann
 CNRS/Université Côte d'Azur

Introduction

The background

The possessor construction and the light verb *have* comes with a wide range of different readings, which raises the question whether there is unified meaning and thus a having-relation.

The observation

The *have*-relation / possessor concept also seems an implicit part of the semantics of a variety of constructions.

Two approaches to 'possessive freedom'

1. The possessor construction or the light verb *have* is a grammatical element that is a *grammatical determinant of thought* in the sense of Hinzen et al. (2024) while being able to associate with various meanings.
 2. Possession / *Have* comes with a unified cognitive meaning, as a *reference-point construction* (Langacker 1993, 1995)
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1. The background

1.1. Readings of *have*

Core readings

Ownership

(1) John has a house.

Structural / functional (nontransitive) parthood

(2) a. The room has a window.

b. The tree has leaves.

(3) a. The library has a lot of books.

b. The book has a lot of pages

c. ?? The library has a lot of pages.

(4) a. The croissant has a lot of butter ??? (in it).

b. ??? The rice has a few black grains.

Ontological dependence

Existence dependence:

(5) a. Socrates has wisdom

b. The tree has a shadow.

c. The bag has a hole.

d. The surface has a dent.

Identity dependence:

(6) The house has a door.

Kinship relations:

(7) a. John has a sister.

Other relations expressed by nouns (Barker 1995):

(7) b. Bill has a supervisor

Experiencerhood. (physical or mental)

(8) a. Joe has a cough.

b. Bill had a dream.

Intentional subject of mental states or occurrences:

(9) Mary had a thought / a wish / an idea.

Non-core readings of *have*

(10) a. I have someone that can help you.

b. I have a new submission.

1.2. The possessor-relation

Shared core readings

- (11) a. the room's window
 b. the tree's leaves
 c. Socrates' wisdom
 d. the trees shadow

Non-core readings:

- (12) a. my candidate
 b. my submission

Divergences between possession and *have*

- (13) a. John's city
 b. John has a city

A common view about the multitude of readings of *have* and the possessor construction

- *Have* is polysemous
 - The possessor relation divides into an open-ended range of relations
 - Which relation is conveyed is never strictly determined by the semantic context (Peters and Westerstahl 1984): 'possessive freedom'
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2. Some further observation about the implicit presence of HAVE or the possessor relation in various constructions

- A *have*/ possessor-relation seems to play a significant role in a range of different semantic phenomena even in the absence of an overt occurrence of *have*.
- Some of the phenomena impose additional constraints.

2.1. Intensional transitive verbs of absence

Intensional transitive verbs of absence: *need, want, search, long for*

The have-relation plays an important role in the satisfaction conditions of needs, wants, searches, lacks even if HAVE is not syntactically present.

2.1.1. *want, need*

- (14) a. John wants / needs a coat.

- b. John wants / needs to have a coat.
- c. John needs exactly one coat.
- d. John needs to have exactly one coat?

German *brauchen* 'need' only comes with a transitive version when not negated:

(15) a. Hans braucht einen Mantel.

John needs a coat

b. * Hans braucht einen Mantel zu haben.

John needs to have a coat.

Satisfaction conditions of the need: 'John's having a coat'

The whole range of readings of *have* allowed?

It seems like the same ranges of readings are allowed (possession, part of rental, daily access, design task)

(16) a. John needs (to have) a pen

b. John wants (to have) a balcony.

c. John needs (to have) someone that can help Mary.

2.1.2. *Look for, search*

Look for, search do not allow for paraphrase with clausal complement, but *have* can appear in formulation of satisfaction conditions:

(17) a. John is looking for a house.

b. John's search is satisfied by John's having a 'suitable house.

Statements of the satisfaction of a need / search

(18) a. I now have what I need.

b. I now have what I was looking for.

Searches also allow different readings of *have*:

(19) Mary is looking for understanding (among other people)

But searches can also have perceptual / recognitional situations as satisfiers, not conveyed by *have*:

(20) a. Looking at the herd, John was searching for a black sheep

- b. John's search is satisfied iff John recognized a black sheep.
- (21) a. Mary is looking for a green car.
- b. Mary finds a green car

Correlation of *look for* with *find*, rather than *have*

But what does *find* mean? 'Recognize', 'come across', 'make/appoint/hire':

- (22) a. Mary found someone suited for the role.
- b. Mary found a pen.
- c. Mary found an assistant.

2.2. Completion-related verbs absence (Moltmann 2024)

Completion-related verbs absence such as *lack* (*John lack a trainer / wisdom / a coat / money*) show a connection to *have*:

*Something x lacks an N just in case it should **have** an N for it to be complete (and does not have it)* (Moltmann 2024).

That is, *lack* applies to unrealized wholes for which the *have*-relation (whatever it may consist in) defines completion.

But lack imposes more constraints:

- (23) a. I have someone that can help you.
- b. ??? I lack someone that can help you.

Lack: relates to an integrated whole, or established type of configuration

2.3. Verbs of replacement

Predicates of replacement like *replace* (conveying the replacement of objects) apply to structured wholes constituted by the various connections that can be conveyed by *have*:

- (24) a. John's teacher / coat / coin was replaced (given that John had a teacher / a coat /
- b. John replaced his assistant.
- c. Mary replaced her handbag.

But also more restricted:

- (25) a. Mary had an idea / a cough / an apple.
 b. ?? Mary replaced the idea / cough / apple

2.4. Explicit property-referring terms

Explicit property-referring terms like *the property of having wisdom / of being wise* are subject to significant and surprising constraints by not accepting eventive or concrete state predicates:

- (26) a. # the property of walking / sleeping / standing
 b. the property of needing a coat
 c. the property of believing that it will rain

Yet *have* + DP appears always possible with any relation *have* may convey:

- (27) a. the property of having a house / a coat / a breakdown / a cold / a frame / an insight...
 b. the property of having a need for a coat
 c. the property of having the belief that it will rain
 d. the property of having someone that can help
 e. the property of having a new submission
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3. What is the status of the multiple readings of *have* / the possessor construction?

Two types of approaches: syntactic and cognitive semantic approach

3.1. Possessor construction / *Have* as a grammatical determinant of thought

- (28) The theory of grammatical determinants of thought (Hinzen, Txuss and Wiltschko 2024)

Grammatical concepts such as Tense, Person are constitutive of thought.

Grammatical concepts

Part of the syntactic structure of sentences (not necessarily manifested in all languages), without being tied to particular semantic concepts

Examples

Tense

past vs. non-past (unmarked)

Mismatch tense – time:

Even past can be used without referring to the past (e.g., conditionals);

future does not involve future tense-making,

Tense as a grammatical category is present, even if not manifest, in all languages.

Person

All nouns are marked for Person (first, second, third)

Person-distinctions encoded throughout morphosyntax.

But Person does not relate to properties of the referent

The view

Tense and Person are constitutive not only of sentences expressing thoughts, but of thoughts themselves.

Application to the possessor relations or HAVE?

The phenomenon is ultimately a syntactic phenomenon involving the presence of the possessor construction or the light verb HAVE, which as such constitutes a linguistic determinant of thought.

HAVE and the possessor construction can associate with different meanings depending on context.

But there are phenomena in which possession / the have-relation seems to be involved without their syntactic presence (intensional transitives).

3.2. A unified cognitive semantic meaning?

The possessor construction and the verb *have* convey certain core-relations, such as ontological dependence (like parthood), ownership and kinship, but they also comprise a great range of context-dependent readings, to the extent that it is often considered impossible to give a unified characterization of those various relations.

A proposal in cognitive semantics

Langacker (1993, 1995):

The possessor construction is a reference-point construction and as such has a unified meaning.

General assumptions of Langacker's cognitive semantics

Non-autonomy of syntactic structure:

Linguistic structure is a manifestation of *cognitive abilities*.

Core cognitive notions driving linguistic structure

Image schema

e.g. container-content, part-whole, core-periphery, figure-ground

Associated cognitive ability:

extract schemas from experiences

Prototype

characterized in terms of notions that are conceptual archetypes

Conceptual archetypes

the human body / face, discrete physical object, agent-patient interactions

Associated cognitive ability:

ability to make extensions from the prototype

More abstract image schemas:

(innate) cognitive *abilities*, rather than cognitive notions

Universal linguistic categories

Natural pairings of essential image-schematic abilities and fundamental conceptual archetypes

Example

Grammatical subject:

Pairing of clause-level figure (within basic cognitive ability of figure-ground organization) with conceptual archetype of agent

Linguistic category of possession

Basic and universal

Manifested in determiner construction, *have* (more constrained), *of*, prepositions that were originally locative

Possession as a cognitive linguistic category

Pairing of image-schematic ability of *reference point* with *multiple archetypes*

Reference point

Ability to invoke the conception of one entity for the purpose of establishing mental contact with another.

The ability does not require explicit attention.

Example

On-switch on a computer requires envisaging computer as a whole first (functional part)

Dent requires envisaging expected shape from which it departs. (ontological dependence)

➔ derive ontological dependence

Components of reference point ability

- Conceptualizer
- Reference point with its dominion: region or set of entities
- Target

Mental path from C, to R to T

Activation of notion required for an entity to serve as reference point

Then *activation* of all elements in R's dominion

Then T becomes focus of C's conception, and T may in turn serve as a reference point.

R recedes into the background in favour of T.

Possession as a reference point construction:

One entity is invoked in order to establish mental contact with another.

Possession clusters around several *archetypes* involving a reference-point relationship:

Ownership, kinship, part-whole relations.

Features of the account

- Sufficiently abstract and flexible
- Asymmetry accounted for

- Centrality of ownership, kinship, part-whole

Kinship relations established through an 'ego', thus identified in an asymmetric construal
Part-whole:

'A part can only be conceived in relation to the whole which functions as a natural reference point for its conception and generalization' (Langacker 1993, p. 9)

Specific part terms - *elbow, tail, roof*: 'invoke as their base the conception of a whole with respect to which it serves to profile (designate) an entity whose nature and subpart status depends on its function within the overall configuration'.

Alternative accounts

1. Possession as metaphorical extension from ownership relation

- ownership culture-specific,
- kinship and part-whole relations are themselves prototypes and thus not to be derived from ownership.
- Inapplicable to nominalizations (*Lincoln's assassination*)

2. Possession as any kind of association between two entities

- Does not account for asymmetries: *the woman's watch*, * *the watch's woman*, *the dog's tail*, * *the tail's dog*

Asymmetries systematic with ownership, kinship, ontological dependencies

Possessive morpheme

conveys reference-point relation

Landmark (denoted by specifier): reference point

Trajectory (denoted by modified noun): target

Locative expression of possession

Construal of reference-point relation in terms of *spatial metaphor*

Spatial search domain (vicinity of landmark) as dominion → possessive search domain

Possession with *have*

Have may in addition convey control (*have a gun, have an income*)

But allows extraction from relations of physical control to schema of reference point

Evaluating the proposal

- The proposal presents a sufficiently general possessor relation that may be part of the semantics of constructions even in the absence of particular grammatical elements.
 - The proposal allows more specific reference-point relations (for *have*, *of*) by imposing constraints through, for example, the activating of archetypes.
 - Is it incompatible with truthconditional semantics?
No, the reference-point relation is established through a cognitive operation, but once established it can become part of truthconditional evaluation.
 - Can the proposal be made precise? In principle yes; formalization is of course possible for cognitive notions; but further work is required, making precise how the notion of a reference point together with archetypes can predict the availability of readings.
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